Chapter 11 – Babur and the Mughal Empire

Sultan Lodi's final enemy went by the name of Babur, and like the rulers of the ruined Sultanate, Babur's heritage was central Asian—specifically, the Timurid Empire. A descendent of Emperor Timur, and possibly even of Genghis Khan, Babur had a royal lineage and a strong desire to establish his own empire. When Sultan Lodi passed, he got his chance to rule over most of India as ruler of the Mughal Empire.

It is somewhat ironic to note that for as much money and military might Alauddin and his family spent keeping the Mongols out of India, it ultimately fell under the command of a Mongol descendent just the same. In fact, the word "Mughal" is most likely a derivation of the original word "Mongol." For India's Hindus, Buddhists, and Jains, little changed, since Babur was a Muslim ruler just as had been the Sultanates.

Babur's people, descended from the Mongol hordes of Genghis Khan, were covetous of a vast country that boasted the world's only known diamond mines, an enticing array of food and spice, and 120 million people who knew how to farm, excavate, spin and weave textiles, build, care for livestock, and create priceless jewelry. They also knew how to fight for their leader, a trait that the Mughal Babur very much wanted to exploit for himself.

It took twenty years and many attempts for the Mughals to penetrate Muslim India, but in 1525 he decided to focus his energy—and that of his relatively sparse army of 12,000—on the powerful city of Delhi. He rode with his troops westward, intent on making this campaign successful. His first move was to lay a trap for the city's skilled leader and protector, Sultan Ibrahim Lodi. The ambush was set at Panipat, a community just a few miles from the city.

Babur settled easily into Panipat with his warriors, knowing that once the Sultan heard of his presence, the latter would ride out to meet him at the head of his defending army. This was a tactic often used in India and throughout Europe by tribal rulers and emperors, intended to allow the heads of opposing forces to discuss potential diplomatic terms. The Mughal conqueror was counting on his enemy following this particular code of